

Spider-Man is one of our favourite superheroes, earning respect for being truly unrecognisable (unlike some, who think that eye-glasses are a perfect cover), and more importantly, for keeping his underwear on the inside where it belongs.

A few years ago, two comic-book illustrators decided to re-invent the Spider-man we all knew and loved to create the *Ultimate Spider-Man* series, giving Peter Parker and his arachnid self a more contemporary teenage look. It might look familiar, too—it airs (or did, at least) on one of our cartoon TV channels.

The story comes right out of the comic, with 15-year-old Peter Parker and friend Eddie Brock discovering a suit their fathers were working on

before they died—a suit that could cure cancer. Peter tries it on, and discovers himself twice the Spider-man he used to be—but there's something sinister about this suit: it begins to consume him. Superhero that he is, Peter escapes its clutches, but Eddie isn't so fortunate when he has a go—the suit turns him into the vicious and brutal Venom.

It's three months later now, and while Peter Parker goes about his superhero responsibilities somewhere in Manhattan, Venom has returned from oblivion to terrorise the city. The story follows the expected comic-book plotline—save the innocent and kick supervillian arse. You're pretty much free to roam the city, taking up challenges like races and gang-fights as you please. While such silly side-mis-

sions feel optional (we'd love to give races the pass), they are in fact the way to unlock further story-related missions and other cool stuff like swing speed upgrades. This didn't go down too well—we'd expected a game that was more strongly focused on story. Instead, what you get is a lot of unnecessary missions that may or may not take you forward in the story.

Thankfully, the few story-related missions that are there are quite intense, and make some of the torture worth it; Spidey fans are sure to enjoy the inclusion of a huge assortment of favourite characters—the Green Goblin, Wolverine, R.H.I.N.O., The Human Torch (of the Fantastic Four), Mary "too-hot-to-pass-for-fifteen" Jane and loads more. While swinging about the city, you can also pick up "tokens"

ULTIMATE SPIDER-MAN

